I'm not drinking beer this tour, just spirits.' It was like I saw the light in Alec Stewart's eyes go out even from across the room.

Whereas Pakistan and other countries had come with a sort of glaze of stardom to them when I first met them, it was different with Australia. Through the television screens and every single cricket conversation I'd ever heard, it had been baked into me from a young age that England lost to Australia. I knew the pain, the heartbreak, the outrage, the searching, the praying from the outside. So, when I am inside, I feel less star-struck about it and more a responsibility on behalf of every English cricket fan I've ever known, to not be part of the same story, to somehow rewrite this pre-written script we were all resigned to. I thought maybe it was coming easily too when, despite bowling a bit out of sorts and at an expensive rate, we had them 135/8 chasing our total of 204.

It's strange how quickly it happened, between Michael Bevan and Andy Bichel. How the story of the game reversed, a sort of inevitability kicking in and just dragging the result to the same one we had always known. How it felt like we were just part of a loss that had already been played out before and we were bound to play out forever. I felt it, like heaviness in my feet, as they clawed the runs back and eventually only required 14 from the last two overs. I couldn't believe it when Nasser threw me the ball, and not Andrew Caddick, for the penultimate over. I almost felt like telling him he'd made a mistake, that surely he didn't want me to bowl this over that would decide the game. In my peripheries I could see Caddick, hands on hips, thinking the same thing. I could almost hear him muttering.

The ball did not do what I wanted. None of the effortlessness fell out of my bones. Instead, Andy Bichel, a bowler by trade, picks up my second ball and despatches me for six over midwicket, before carting me down the ground on the leg side for another four. The game was done. I had blown it. I left the field in what felt like dusk, dust everywhere, now part of a story I'd seen from the outside, an English defeat against Australia, somehow snatching defeat from the jaws of victory.

Nasser put his arm around me in the dressing room straight after, my head bowed, putting away my gear, and simply said, 'I could have given Caddick that over. I wanted you to bowl it.' He was telling me that he trusted me and that he would do it again. It was supposed to help me, and in a way it did, but I just felt the cloud, that darkness of losing, the same as it